

Alex Caramanico
Professor McGurrin
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Why The Beatles are the Most Important Band of All Time

Undoubtedly one of the most famous and influential bands in history, the Beatles revolutionized music in many ways. Their impact is virtually unquantifiable, as their music remains immensely popular to this day despite their breaking up over fifty years ago. Thus, it is reasonable to say that the Beatles were crucial in developing several musical genres, or at least in helping to boost the popularity of said genres, and in inspiring millions of people across the world to pursue careers in music. This speech will explore the everlasting impact and influence of the Beatles, and argue for them as the most important band of all time. In doing so, it may begin to sway those who disagree with the arguments in the opposite direction.

The first reason one might cite for the Beatles being the most important band in history would be their lasting impact. Despite the fact they broke up more than fifty years ago, their music is still extremely popular and ubiquitous. There are millions of people across the entire world who idolize the Beatles or at least consider them a major part of their lives. It is quite possible that everyone in the major countries of the world knows at least one person who is a major fan of the group, if they are not already one themselves. Their music is still heard on a daily basis as it pervades our modern society and culture - hundreds of millions of people are at least aware of their existence and many thousands routinely enjoy their music. There are several examples of the Beatles' prevalence. One might be able to recall seeing advertisements with their songs included, immediately I remember ads with "From Me To You", "All You Need is Love", and "Hello Goodbye". Further, several major radio stations consistently play Beatles songs, some of them even dedicating full days to their music. This is another factor which adds to the ubiquity and popularity of the band, even fifty years later. Thirdly, new material related to the Beatles is almost always immensely popular upon release. Peter Jackson's "The Beatles: Get Back" documentary could be cited in addition to the fact that interviews with the surviving members garner millions upon millions of views over the internet. The Beatles are perpetually a topic of conversation on social media as well - young and old fans alike connect with each other by discussing their favorite songs, albums, and thoughts about the band. All of these factors certainly prove the Beatles lasting impact, and it is impossible to claim a band as the most important of all time if said band did not have such a significant effect on world cultures. This also leads into the next argument which is their innate ability to have a genuine emotional effect on their audience.

It can also be argued that the Beatles' music covered such a wide range of genres that anyone can find at least one song they enjoy. This is especially true of their music from 1966 and onward, where their music began to evolve in a multitude of ways. One might cite the fact that

they began by writing songs such as “Please Please Me”, with a relatively simple form and structure, and “Strawberry Fields Forever”, which broke ground in many musical areas with its use of more complex chords, a complicated structure, and a dense orchestral arrangement backing the band. It should also be noted that the song utilizes the mellotron instrument, tape loops, and speed changes, all of which were quite experimental and novel at the time. These two songs were written only five years apart, and are so different that it may be difficult to believe they are by the same band. Further, their self-titled “White” album contains perhaps the most varied music of any 20th century album. The album shifts from more traditional rock songs with “Back in the USSR”, to upbeat pop dance with “Ob-La-Di Ob-La-Da”, to complex introspection with “While My Guitar Gently Weeps” and “Happiness is a Warm Gun”, to theatrical and orchestral with “Martha My Dear”, to purely acoustic with “Blackbird”, to spoof country with “Rocky Raccoon”, and even to a heavy metal precursor with “Helter Skelter”. This is to say that their music was incredibly variable, which contributes to the argument that any individual can find at least one song they actually like, even if they do not care for any of the others.

It was mentioned in a previous paragraph that the Beatles pioneered many musical revolutions, such as speed changes, tape loops, backward tracks, and most importantly their use of multi-track tapes when recording. While the band may not have been the very first to use such techniques, they can certainly be credited with popularizing them and introducing them to a world-wide audience. This ties directly into their musical expertise and consistency, areas in which they were exceptional. It is extremely difficult, if not impossible, to find a Beatles song which is legitimately poor. Even in their early music where many of the songs were covers of other artists’ work, many fans believed that the Beatles’ versions were superior with their tight harmonies, pleasant singing, and instrumental precision. As the band grew older, their music became increasingly complex without sacrificing their ability. In fact, many have argued that the Beatles became better musicians with every album, culminating with “Abbey Road”, which is often cited as one of the greatest albums of all time. Many of their best songs were not even singles or A-sides, such as “For No One”, “Across the Universe”, “Dear Prudence”, and “Because”. These songs were technically album filler, though they would probably be considered the best song for basically any band if they were not written by the Beatles. One could easily make a twenty-song album of just their underrated and forgotten songs, and it would likely be immensely popular. Consistency and improvement over time are arguably the two most important measures when assessing the quality of a band. Since the Beatles were one of the best ever in both of these measures, it is only logical to say that they belong among the greatest in music history, quite possibly above all others. This becomes even more logical when factoring in their influence on revolutionary musical practices, many of which are ubiquitous in today’s music.

In addition to revolutionary nature and the quality of their music, the Beatles did not necessarily shy away from political activism both within their songs and in their lives. They wrote several songs with important political messages, such as “Blackbird”, which was about the Civil Rights Movement and metaphorically equates the oppression of African Americans to a

bird. It is in this song where their lyrical expertise is apparent as well, Paul McCartney sings “take these broken wings and learn to fly” and “all your life, you were only waiting for this moment to arise.” Another example would be “Get Back”, which was originally written in regard to controversial and racist immigration policies of the time, and was intended to be in protest to white supremacy. This ties into their political activism in general - all four of the Beatles pursued or are currently pursuing causes in support of those less fortunate than themselves, and have always placed a heavy emphasis on love and peace between all people. There was one instance in which the Beatles refused to perform for a segregated audience in Jacksonville unless it was integrated. Further, it was argued by musician Jonathan Gould that the Beatles helped fuel movements such as women’s liberation, gay liberation, and environmentalism. A counter argument would be that the Beatles could have done more with the power and influence that they possessed, but it should not be ignored that they did in fact have a dramatic impact in these areas. Since the Beatles were so immensely popular, any of their ideologies and values were bound to be distributed among the masses. People would at the very least have been aware of their activism, and at the most become components of activism themselves. This is arguably the most important aspect about the Beatles, because it proves that they truly cared about using their platform for the improvement of society when it likely would have been easier for them to sit back and simply enjoy their success.

Another argument for the importance of the Beatles would be their quantitative success. No matter which measure is examined, the group stands above the rest in terms of sales and popularity. According to an article by Peter Lee, the Beatles have sold well over one billion records, had twenty No. 1 songs in the United States, 16 of the 100 most successful tracks of all time and 7 of the most successful albums. Several of their most popular songs spent weeks at the top spot in the charts, such as “Hey Jude”, which held the spot for nine consecutive weeks, a record which was not broken until the late 1970s. A counter argument would be that sales are not always indicative of quality, but it is certainly arguable that there must be a reason for such popularity. If something was not particularly palatable, it would not see as much success. In addition, their incredible sales prove how impactful they were on society by assigning numerical values to it. It should also be emphasized that the Beatles achieved all of these things in just seven years.

Upon examining all the evidence and arguments in favor of the Beatles’ importance, it is reasonable to come to the conclusion that they were in fact the most influential and crucial band in history. This conclusion could then be expanded to say that they were and remain one of the most popular bands of all time. The group achieved unimaginable success and lofty heights which have yet to be rivalled, doing so by revolutionizing the music industry and world cultures thusly. Their impact is very difficult to quantify adequately, but it is certainly true that their music influenced thousands upon thousands of musicians who may not have pursued careers in music otherwise. The Beatles music continues to pervade modern society, and its effects will definitely be felt forever.

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